KINGSFORD ONYINA

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Education

University of North Carolina at Charlotte — Charlotte, NC
PhD Public Policy — Expected 2027
Graduate Certificate, Quantitative Analyses

Eastern Illinois University — Charleston, IL
MA Economics — 2023

University of Education, Winneba — Winneba, Ghana
BA Economics & Political Science (Minor) — 2020

Research Interests

Poverty and Income Policy, Child and Family Policy, and Program Evaluation

Job Market Paper

Welfare Reform and the Noncognitive Skill Formation of the Next Generation

Noncognitive skills (NCS) are an important dimension of human capital shaped by early-life environments, yet little is known about how social safety-net reform affects them over the long run. I study exposure to the 1990s U.S. welfare reform from conception through age five using the Panel Study of Income Dynamics and its Child Development and Transition into Adulthood Supplements. Exploiting variation across states, birth cohorts, and families' likelihood of being affected in a triple-difference design, I find that early-life exposure reduced young-adult NCS by 0.24 standard deviations among children most likely to be affected, with declines concentrated in agreeableness and openness. Suggestive mechanism evidence points to changes in early caregiving arrangements: formal childcare increased while household income and maternal employment changed little, and adverse effects are concentrated once the child aged past the state's exemption threshold and the work requirement bound on the mother, rather than while she remained exempt. A follow-up augmented Mincer analysis shows that the affected traits are negatively associated with earnings, so their decline implies a modest early-career earnings gain rather than a loss. Reduced-form estimates also show higher employment through a margin the measured NCS changes do not explain. Welfare reform thus left a lasting socioemotional imprint while shaping early labor-market attachment along a distinct margin. [Latest version]

Working Papers

Does Expanding SNAP Eligibility Reduce Crime? Evidence from Broad-Based Categorical Eligibility

Evidence linking food assistance to crime generally studies the amount, timing, delivery, or withdrawal of benefits among populations already eligible for assistance. The consequences of the rules determining who can enter a program remain less understood. I study this eligibility margin through Broad-Based Categorical Eligibility (BBCE), which thirty-two states adopted between 2000 and 2010 to relax SNAP asset and income screens while leaving the federal benefit formula unchanged. Combining USDA policy and participation data with arrest records that local law enforcement agencies report to the FBI from 1996 through 2016, I exploit staggered state adoption in a stacked difference-in-differences design. The findings indicate that BBCE increases SNAP participation by 8 percent and reduces adult arrests by 8 to 9 percent across the total, violent, and property offense indices. The results are robust across alternative comparison groups, estimators, samples, and treatment definitions. They indicate that eligibility design affects not only program participation but also criminal justice contact, a consequence not captured by the program's caseload or budget. [Draft available on request]

Cash Transfer and the Labor Supply of Vulnerable Households and Individuals: Does Household Indebtedness Matter? with *Danny Turkson* (UNC Chapel Hill)

Cash transfer programs are central to poverty reduction, yet their effects on labour supply remain contested in developing economies. Evidence ranges from reductions to neutrality or even increases in work effort, underscoring the need to consider household conditions that shape responses. One such condition is indebtedness, a widespread feature of low-income settings that influences both consumption and labour decisions. This study examines how debt moderates the labour supply effects of Ghana's LEAP 1000 program, where beneficiary households carried higher baseline debt burdens than the rural population nationally. Using household panel data and a triple-difference design, we analyze heterogeneity by debt status, amount, type, source, and gender. Findings highlight the central role of indebtedness in conditioning program impacts. Indebted beneficiaries increase wage work, total hours, and non-farm enterprise (NFE) formation, unlike debt-free households, where income effects dominate. Gender differences are evident: male-headed households expand both wage work and self-employment, while female-headed households benefit more from formal credit, which facilitates entrepreneurship. Debt type and source also matter. Investment and consumption debt reinforce participation in wage labour and enterprise, while informal borrowing pushes households into wage work under repayment pressure. Formal credit, by contrast, enables longer-term entrepreneurial activity, particularly among women.

Publications

Onyina, K. (2026). Universal Access, Divided Opinions: A Latent Class Analysis of Public Perceptions of Ghana's Free Senior High School Policy. *Social Policy and Society*, 1–17.

Oboro-Offerie, R. A., & **Onyina, K.** (2026). Quantifying the Effect of Partisanship on Citizens Collective Action Against Corruption in African Democracies: A Quasi-Experimental Approach. *International Criminology*, 6(1), 69–88.

Onyina, K., Oboro-Offerie, R. A., & Akoto, O. D. A. (2025). Unpacking the multidimensional impact of international remittances on women's empowerment in Africa: a quasi-experimental study. *SN Social Sciences*, 5(10), 163.

Aremu, T., Baye, R. S., **Onyina, K.**, & Abijah, P. (2025). Agricultural extension services and household welfare: evidence from Ghana socioeconomic panel survey. *Agricultural and Food Economics*, 13(1), 58.

Oboro-Offerie, R. A., Allor, P. W., Toklo, S., & **Onyina, K.** (2025). To report or not to report corruption? An empirical investigation of the determinants of corruption reporting in Africa. *Crime, Law and Social Change*, 83(1), 1–29.

Onyina, K., & Baye, R. S. (2024). Impact of social protection policies on inclusive growth in Sub-Saharan Africa: evidence from bias-corrected dynamic panel. *Cogent Economics & Finance*, 12(1), 2409421.

Articles Under Review

Burden or Necessity? Experimental Evidence on Public Perceptions of SNAP's Work Requirement for College Students. *Administration & Society*.

When You Don't Know Your Voting Rights: How Knowledge of Voting Requirements Shapes Voter Confidence. *Electoral Studies*, with *Martha Kropf & Thessalia Merivaki* (R&R).

Works in Progress

Does Expanding SNAP Eligibility Save Lives? with *Humphrey Ashimatey (Georgia State University)*.

Work Without Wealth? The Long-Run Effects of Welfare Reform on Family Wealth.

Welfare Reform Across Three Generations: Early-Life Exposure and Grandchild Health.

The Sibling Dividend: Free Senior High School and Intrahousehold Human Capital Spillovers in Ghana, with *Vanessa Owusu-Ansah & Danny Turkson*.

Conferences & Presentations († Scheduled)

2027 Allied Social Science Associations (ASSA)/American Economic Association Annual Meeting, Washington, DC†

2026 48th Annual Conference of the Association for Public Policy & Management, Boston, MA†
96th Annual Meeting of the Southern Economic Association, Houston, TX†
Carolina Regional Empirical Economics†
Panel Study of Income Dynamics Annual User Conference†
Talking Policy in the Queen City, Charlotte, NC

2025 47th Annual Meeting of the Association for Public Policy & Management, Seattle, WA
Graduate Research Symposium, UNC Charlotte, Charlotte, NC
33rd Annual Conference of the Global Awareness Society International, Hot Springs, AR

2024 88th Midwest Economics Annual Conference, Chicago, IL
Talking Policy in the Queen City, Charlotte, NC

Research Experience

University of North Carolina at Charlotte — Charlotte, NC
Research Assistant, Department of Economics — 2024
Supervisors: Dr. Kelly Vosters & Dr. Lisa Schulkind

Eastern Illinois University — Charleston, IL
Research Assistant, Faculty of Development and Innovation Center — 2022 – 2023
Research Project: "Meaningful Data Sets for EIU Students."
Principal Investigators: Dr. Alejandra Alvarado and Dr. Andrew Mertz.

Teaching Experience

University of North Carolina at Charlotte — Charlotte, NC

Instructor of Record

ECON 3112 – Econometrics	Fall 2026
SOCY 4156 – Quantitative Analysis	Summer 2026
SOCY 4156L – Quantitative Analysis Lab	Summer 2026

Teaching Assistant

ECON 4141/5141 – Health Economics	Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026
PPOL 8641 – Economic Analysis of Public Policy II	Spring 2025 & 2026
DSBA/ECON 6112 – Graduate Econometrics	Spring 2024 & 2025
ECON 3112 – Econometrics	Fall 2023, Fall 2024, Fall 2025

Eastern Illinois University — Charleston, IL
Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics

ECN 2801G – Principles of Macroeconomics	Fall 2021 – Spring 2023
ECN 2802G – Principles of Microeconomics	Fall 2021 – Spring 2023

University of Education, Winneba — Winneba, Ghana
Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics Education — Fall 2020 – Summer 2021
ECNS 231 – Elements of Microeconomics
ECNS 242 – Economy of Ghana
ECNS 354 – Labor Economics

Computing Skills & Datasets

Software: Stata, RStudio, Python, LaTeX.

Datasets: PSID, Add Health, CPS, SIPP, Afrobarometer, WDI, WGI.

Honors, Awards, Grants

2025 Graduate Life Fellow (UNC Charlotte, Graduate School)
National Association for Welfare Research and Statistics (Conference grant)
Graduate Research Symposium (2nd Place, Oral Presentation)
Global Awareness Society Conference Travel Scholarship

2024 Graduate School Conference Travel Award
Conference Travel Grant, Graduate & Professional Student Government

2023 Distinguished Economics Graduate Student, Eastern Illinois University
Distinguished International Graduate Student Award, Eastern Illinois University
Donna and Kabbarsion Scholarship, Eastern Illinois University
Graduate Student Advisory Council Scholarship, Eastern Illinois University

2020 Vice Chancellor Scholarship Fund by merit (x2), University of Education, Winneba

University and Professional Service

President, Graduate Public Policy Association (GPPA), UNC Charlotte 2025
Graduate School Admissions Ambassador, UNC Charlotte (x2) 2024/2026
UNC Charlotte Undergraduate Research Conference Poster Judge 2024
APPAM Fall Research Conference Poster Judge 2024

Outreach and Mentoring

Founder, QuantBridge 2026 – Present

- Runs a webinar series on applied quasi-experimental methods for early-career researchers.
- Convenes brown bag sessions on graduate admissions, research design, and professional development.

Educational Content Creator, YouTube (66K+ subscribers; 2M+ views, September 2026) 2021 – Present

- Produces videos on graduate admissions, academic preparation, and access to higher education.
- Reaches viewers in more than 30 countries, with a focus on students from low-resource backgrounds.

Professional Training

- Panel Study of Income Dynamics (PSID) Data User Workshop (2026)
- Social Protection, Non-Credit Virtual Training, Bureau for Research & Economic Analysis of Development (2025)
- Impact Evaluation Methods with Applications in Low and Middle-Income Countries, World Bank Group (2024)

Professional Associations

- Association for Public Policy and Management; Southern Economic Association; American Economic Association; Midwest Economics Association.
- Graduate Public Policy Association, UNC Charlotte; Graduate & Professional Student Government, UNC Charlotte.

Service to the Field / Review

Humanities and Social Sciences Communications, Discover Global Society, Discover Public Health, Journal of International Migration and Integration, Discover Education.

References

Kelly N. Vosters, PhD (Dissertation Chair)
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University of North Carolina at Charlotte
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Professor
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